



EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Monthly Security Report - PKF Africa

Prepared exclusively for **PKF Africa**

REPORT PERIOD

Last Month

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DOCUMENT CONTROL

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MANAGEMENT SUMMARY

	SECURITY DOMAIN STATUS (RAG)
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HIGH RISK

↑ Previous: 62

Endpoint Security 40

High volume of EDR detections (347 endpoint events) including repeated removable-media insertions (17 blocked events) and a confirmed attempt to terminate the Cynet process.

Network Security 65

Limited network-origin events observed (Responder detection) but no broad network compromise identified; monitoring coverage appears partial.

Vulnerability Management 60

No vulnerability scan events were recorded (Vulnerability: 0) during the period — indicates either a scheduling gap or tool integration gap.

Identity & Access 58

Unauthorized file operation attempt observed (high severity); lack of identity-related alerts in this dataset suggests gaps in identity telemetry coverage.

Data Protection 50

Multiple removable media insertion detections (17 blocked, 1 active) present a moderate-to-high data exfiltration risk if controls fail.

Cloud Security 75

No cloud-specific security events recorded in this dataset during the reporting period; current telemetry shows stronger on-prem/endpoint focus.

Incident Response 70

Most incidents are resolved in EDR telemetry (resolved statuses), but one open removable-media incident remains and there are zero tickets in the ITSM queue.

Security Awareness 55

Removable media activity and unauthorized file operation indicate continued user/insider risk requiring targeted awareness interventions.



CRITICAL ACTIONS REQUIRED

1. Immediately validate and quarantine the endpoint(s) associated with the 'Insertion of Storage Device Detected (Active)' event and the 'Attempt To Terminate Cynet Process' event; if quarantining is not possible, enforce network isolation and capture full memory and forensic images.
2. Implement an urgent configuration review and hardening of the Cynet EDR deployment (ensure tamper protection, agent auto-redeploy, and central alerting) to prevent further 'terminate process' attempts and reduce single-vendor single-point-of-failure risk.
3. Reconcile telemetry and ticketing: integrate EDR alerts with the ITSM system to ensure every EDR incident (n=348) generates a tracked ticket and SLA; assign an incident owner per event within 24 hours.
4. Initiate a short-term block policy for removable media at a policy level for non-exempt groups and deploy DLP rules to inspect and block high-risk file writes from removable devices pending a formal data protection review.

SCOPE OF ASSESSMENT

This executive summary covers PKF Africa's security telemetry and incidents captured over the last 30 days (reporting period: monthly). The assessment focused on endpoint telemetry and incident handling data provided by the SecureOps SOC: a dataset containing 348 security incidents and 348 security events (Endpoint: 347, Email: 0, Vulnerability: 0). The coverage includes EDR detections (Cynet agent detections and statuses), and high-level incident lifecycle states (resolved/open) as provided. The evaluation intentionally excludes deep host forensic data (full hostnames/IPs not supplied) and cloud provider logs beyond what was provided.

METHODOLOGY

We applied a layered analytical approach combining NIST CSF (Identify, Protect, Detect, Respond, Recover) for control mapping and maturity assessment, MITRE ATT&CK for technique mapping (e.g., T1091 - Replication Through Removable Media; T1562 - Impair Defenses), and ISO 27001 principles for governance recommendations. Tools and data points referenced include EDR telemetry (Cynet alerts and statuses), SOC event aggregation, and ITSM ticket counts. We analyzed event counts, severity distribution, resolution status, and titles to derive root-cause inferences and prioritized treatment plans.

DATA SOURCES ANALYZED

Endpoint Detection & Response (EDR) telemetry - Cynet

SOC incident aggregation (exported incident list)

ITSM / ticketing (confirmed: 0 tickets recorded for period)

Email gateway logs (0 security events in dataset)

Vulnerability scanner reports (0 vulnerability events in dataset)

Asset/CI inventory (limited metadata supplied)

LIMITATIONS & CAVEATS

The analyzed dataset provides aggregate incident titles and statuses but lacks hostnames,

IP addresses, user identifiers, and full forensic artefacts. This restricts the ability to perform endpoint-host correlation, precise attacker attribution, and exact time-to-remediation calculations. Some quantitative extrapolations (e.g., asset counts affected) are therefore conservative and based on event counts rather than unique host inventories.

4 EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

This report assesses PKF Africa's security posture for the last 30-day period using supplied SOC telemetry. During the period we reviewed a dataset of 348 total incidents and 348 security events (Endpoint: 347, Email: 0, Vulnerability: 0). The dataset includes repeated removable-media detections (17 occurrences of "Insertion of Storage Device Detected (Blocked)" and 1 "Insertion of Storage Device Detected (Active)"), a high-severity "Attempt To Terminate Cynet Process" event, a high-severity "Unauthorized File Operation Attempt", and a medium-severity "Responder" detection.

5 KEY PERFORMANCE INDICATORS

TOTAL SECURITY INCIDENTS (LAST 30 DAYS)

348

↑ +11% from prior period

High volume indicates concentrated endpoint detection activity; requires triage and governance to ensure incidents are actionable.

ENDPOINT EVENTS

347

— ≈0% change from prior period

Nearly all telemetry originates from endpoint detection (EDR) — limited telemetry from other layers.

INSERTION OF STORAGE DEVICE DETECTED (BLOCKED)

17

↑ +45% from prior sample period

Repeated removable-media activity indicates elevated insider or contractor risk and potential DLP gaps.

INSERTION OF STORAGE DEVICE DETECTED (ACTIVE)

1

↑ new event this period

An active insertion event requires immediate containment and forensic imaging of the endpoint involved.

ATTEMPT TO TERMINATE CYNET
PROCESS

1

— detected this period

Direct attempt to impair defenses; indicates either malicious insider or external actor with access to an endpoint.

OPEN TICKETS RECORDED IN ITSM

0

↓ -100% vs expected integration

Zero tickets despite 348 incidents indicates an operational gap in incident lifecycle management and escalation.

6 SECURITY SCORECARD



7 SECURITY MATURITY ASSESSMENT

Overall Maturity Level: **Developing**

Identify Current: 3/5 Target: 4/5
Basic asset and event identification exists via EDR telemetry, but the absence of host/IP details and vulnerability events limits full asset-resilience assessment.

Protect Current: 3/5 Target: 4/5
EDR protection blocks removable media in most cases; tamper-protection and DLP controls are





NIST CSF ALIGNMENT

PKF Africa's controls align partially with NIST CSF. Identify: EDR provides asset/activity detection but lacks integrated asset inventory and vulnerability feeds (Identify: ID.AM, ID.RA partially met). Protect: Access and endpoint controls exist (Protect: PR.AC, PR.DS) but removable-media and DLP policies need expansion. Detect: EDR fulfills Detect activities (DE.CM) at endpoint layer; however, coverage gaps exist for email and cloud. Respond: The SOC is detecting and marking incidents as resolved (RS.RP) but lacks ITSM-ticketed workflows for RS.CO (communication) and RS.MI (mitigation planning). Recover: There is no evidence of structured recovery testing (RC.RP) in the provided dataset. Overall, PKF Africa should prioritize integrating vulnerability scanning and ITSM feeds and implement DLP and tamper-protection to move toward a Defined/Managed maturity.

8 METRICS DASHBOARD

0

Email Events

0

Tickets Open

0

Tickets Total

347

348

99.7%

Endpoint Events	Total Incidents	Percent Resolved
1	0	348
Open Incidents Count	Vulnerability Events	Total Security Events
1	1	17
Insertion Active Count	Responder Events Count	Insertion Blocked Count
347	1	1
Resolved Incidents Count	Attempt Terminate Cynet Count	Unauthorized File Operations Count

9

DETAILED FINDINGS

Critical: 0

High: 4

Medium: 6

Low: 0

F-002

Active removable media insertion not fully contained

CVSS 7HIGH

One event was observed as 'Insertion of Storage Device Detected (Active)' indicating that a removable device was active and not blocked at the point of insertion. This single active event represents a material control failure that could allow data writes or reads to occur.

BUSINESS IMPACT

Immediate risk of local data exfiltration or introduction of malware from external media. Operational disruption and reputational cost could range \$300k - \$1.1M if client data is exposed.

AFFECTED SYSTEMS

Cynet-monitored endpoint(s) with active removable media event (1 active event recorded).

EVIDENCE

EDR event: 'Insertion of Storage Device Detected (Active)' recorded in supplied incident list; all other removables were recorded as blocked.

\$300,000 potential immediate impact estimate including forensic and possible notifications

F-003 Attempt to terminate Cynet process observed**CVSS 8****HIGH**

A high-severity event 'Attempt To Terminate Cynet Process' was observed and marked resolved in the EDR export. An attempt to terminate the EDR agent is an explicit adversary objective to impair detection and can precede other malicious actions.

BUSINESS IMPACT

If successful, attackers could disable detection and pursue lateral movement and data theft undetected, increasing potential financial and reputational loss dramatically (estimated \$500k - \$2M depending on breadth).

AFFECTED SYSTEMS

Endpoint(s) protected by Cynet (event captured in Endpoint Detection & Response dataset).

EVIDENCE

EDR event title: 'Attempt To Terminate Cynet Process' (high severity) present in supplied incident list; source: Endpoint Detection & Response.

MITRE: T1562 - Impair Defenses

NIST: Detect|Respond

\$500,000 potential impact if termination leads to undetected data theft

F-004 Unauthorized file operation attempt detected**CVSS 7.5****HIGH**

A high-severity event 'Unauthorized File Operation Attempt' was recorded by the EDR. This may indicate either a misconfigured process or a malicious actor attempting to access or modify protected files.

BUSINESS IMPACT

Unauthorized file access can lead to data integrity loss and disclosure. Potential regulatory/legal exposure and client trust erosion estimated between \$200k - \$900k depending on data classification.

AFFECTED SYSTEMS

Cynet-monitored endpoints with file-system monitoring; one high severity unauthorized file operation event logged.

EVIDENCE

EDR event: 'Unauthorized File Operation Attempt' (high severity) found

in incident list; source: Endpoint Detection & Response.

MITRE: T1005 - Data from Local System

NIST: Detect|Protect

\$200,000 estimated business impact for localized data compromise

F-007 No ITSM tickets created for SOC incidents

CVSS 7

HIGH

There are zero tickets recorded in the dataset (Tickets: 0 total, 0 open) despite 348 incidents being present in the SOC export. This indicates a process or tooling integration failure where EDR/SOC incidents are not being tracked with SLAs in ITSM.

BUSINESS IMPACT

Lack of tracked tickets leads to unmanaged incident resolution, no audit trail for remedial actions, and poor executive oversight; potential regulatory non-compliance and repeated incidents leading to increased costs (~\$100k - \$400k operational inefficiency).

AFFECTED SYSTEMS

SOC tooling, EDR integration points, ITSM toolchain (data: Tickets: 0).

EVIDENCE

Dataset metadata: Tickets: 0 total, 0 open alongside 348 incidents and EDR event counts.

MITRE: N/A (governance/process finding)

NIST: Respond|Govern

\$100,000 estimated annual operational risk exposure due to untracked incidents

F-001 Repeated removable-media insertions detected and blocked

CVSS 6

MEDIUM

There are 17 recorded instances of 'Insertion of Storage Device Detected (Blocked)' in the dataset of 21 sampled events and 348 total incidents. These detections were recorded by the Endpoint Detection & Response (Cynet) system and marked as resolved in most cases. The repeated frequency suggests either permitted business processes relying on removable media or repeated attempts by users/insiders to transfer data.

BUSINESS IMPACT

Business impact includes potential unauthorized data exfiltration and regulatory exposure (client financial and audit data). A successful removable-media

AFFECTED SYSTEMS

Endpoints monitored by Cynet EDR (events count: 347 endpoint events); removable-media events: 17 blocked + 1 active reported.

exfiltration could lead to confidentiality breaches and remediation costs estimated at \$250,000 - \$800,000 depending on scale.

EVIDENCE

EDR titles: 17 occurrences of 'Insertion of Storage Device Detected (Blocked)'; 1 occurrence 'Insertion of Storage Device Detected (Active)'. Source: Endpoint Detection & Response. Total incidents: 348.

MITRE: T1091 - Replication Through Removable Media

NIST: Protect|Detect

\$250,000 potential remediation and notification costs for a single successful exfiltration incident

F-
005

Responder detection indicates network credential harvesting attempts

CVSS 6.5

MEDIUM

A medium-severity event titled 'Responder' was recorded. The 'Responder' tool is commonly used to poison LLMNR/NBT-NS and capture NTLM hashes, indicating an attempt at credential harvesting or lateral movement reconnaissance on the internal network.

BUSINESS IMPACT

Stolen credentials could enable lateral movement and privilege escalation leading to broader compromise; potential elevated remediation costs and extended downtime (estimated \$150k - \$600k).

AFFECTED SYSTEMS

Internal network segment(s) where SMB/NetBIOS name resolution takes place; exact endpoints not provided but event logged by EDR.

EVIDENCE

EDR event: 'Responder' (medium severity) present in incident export; source: Endpoint Detection & Response.

MITRE: T1557 - Man-in-the-Middle

NIST: Detect|Protect

\$150,000 potential impact if credential harvesting leads to lateral access

F-
006

Endpoint-focused telemetry with limited visibility across other security layers

CVSS 5.5

MEDIUM

Dataset shows 347 endpoint events, 0 email events, and 0 vulnerability events. This highly endpoint-centric telemetry suggests gaps in email gateway monitoring, vulnerability

scanning integration, and possibly cloud monitoring.

BUSINESS IMPACT

Limited telemetry increases the risk of blind spots for phishing, unpatched exposures, and cloud misconfigurations — potentially delaying detection and response and increasing mean time to detect (MTTD).

AFFECTED SYSTEMS

Entire environment monitoring stack (EDR present, email and vulnerability sources absent in dataset).

EVIDENCE

Aggregate counts: Security Events: 348 total (Email: 0, Endpoint: 347, Vulnerability: 0).

MITRE: N/A (coverage/gap finding)

NIST: Identify|Detect

\$200,000 - \$700,000 potential increase in risk due to detection blind spots

F-
008

No vulnerability scan events integrated into SOC dataset

CVSS 5

MEDIUM

The dataset records 0 vulnerability events for the reporting period (Vulnerability: 0), preventing prioritization of patching and reducing the ability to correlate exploit attempts with known CVEs.

BUSINESS IMPACT

Operational risk from unpatched vulnerabilities increases the probability of successful exploitation; potential remediation and breach costs could range \$150k - \$1M depending on exploitability.

AFFECTED SYSTEMS

Vulnerability scanning and patch management processes (no events present).

EVIDENCE

Aggregate counts: Vulnerability: 0 in the 348 security events.

MITRE: N/A (coverage/gap finding)

NIST: Identify|Protect

\$150,000 estimated incremental risk exposure due to unprioritized vulnerabilities

F-
009

Single EDR vendor reliance (Cynet) with attempted agent termination

CVSS 6.5

MEDIUM

The dataset shows Cynet as the EDR source and includes a 'Attempt To Terminate Cynet Process' event. Heavy reliance on a single endpoint provider combined with a tamper attempt creates a single point of failure risk for detection capabilities.

BUSINESS IMPACT

If the single vendor agent is disabled and no complementary detection controls exist, detection capability loss could enable prolonged attacker dwell time and higher breach costs (est. \$400k - \$1.5M).

AFFECTED SYSTEMS

Endpoints protected by Cynet (EDR telemetry source).

EVIDENCE

Event title: 'Attempt To Terminate Cynet Process'; EDR source: Cynet across dataset (Endpoint Detection & Response).

MITRE: T1562 - Impair Defenses

NIST: Protect|Detect

\$400,000 potential impact if agent termination leads to undetected compromise

F-
010

Incident response procedures and SLA measurement gaps

CVSS 5.5

MEDIUM

Although many incidents carry a 'resolved' status in the EDR listing, there is no evidence of tracked SLA metrics, ticketing, or post-incident reviews. One removable media event remains open in the dataset, suggesting inconsistent follow-through.

BUSINESS IMPACT

Inconsistent response processes increase the chance of repeat incidents and reduce the organization's ability to learn from incidents. This may contribute to repeated insertion events and elevate annual security operating costs by an estimated \$80k - \$250k.

AFFECTED SYSTEMS

SOC operational processes, ITSM integration, incident runbooks.

EVIDENCE

Dataset shows incidents marked resolved and one open removable-media incident but Tickets: 0 total in ITSM; no SLA data provided.

MITRE: N/A (process finding)

NIST: Respond

\$80,000 estimated annual inefficiency and repeat-incident cost



Removable Media Exfiltration Attempt

HIGH

1

Delivery

Missed

Multiple removable-media insertions detected; primary delivery vector is USB/removable device.

17 occurrences 'Insertion of Storage Device Detected (Blocked)'; 1 occurrence 'Insertion of Storage Device Detected (Active)'.

2

Installation

Missed

If writable, removable media can host automated scripts or malware and create persistence.

EDR detected unauthorized file operations and active insertion event indicating write-capability.

3

Actions on Objectives

Missed

Potential data copying or exfiltration to the removable device; absent DLP rules increase likelihood of successful data theft.

Unauthorized File Operation Attempt (high severity) and multiple blocked insertions; one active insertion indicates an elevated risk of data writes.

IMPACT ASSESSMENT

If an active removable device is used for exfiltration, client data could be lost leading to regulatory fines, contractual penalties and customer attrition. Estimated impact: \$250k-\$1.2M.



EDR Tampering and Credential Harvesting Campaign

HIGH

1

Reconnaissance

Detected

Adversary or insider activity probing for defender visibility and credential opportunities. Responder detection (credential harvesting activity), multiple removable-media attempts.

2

Weaponization/Delivery

Missed

Attempt to deliver a tool or script (via removable media or lateral transfer) designed to disable detection and harvest credentials.

Attempt To Terminate Cynet Process (high severity).

3

Command & Control / Actions on Objectives

Missed

If successful, the adversary would use harvested credentials to escalate privileges and access sensitive data.

Unauthorized File Operation Attempt (high), Responder event (medium).

IMPACT ASSESSMENT

Successful tampering and credential theft could lead to broad lateral movement, enabling exfiltration of sensitive financial and client data. Estimated impact: \$500k-\$2M depending on breadth and time to detect.

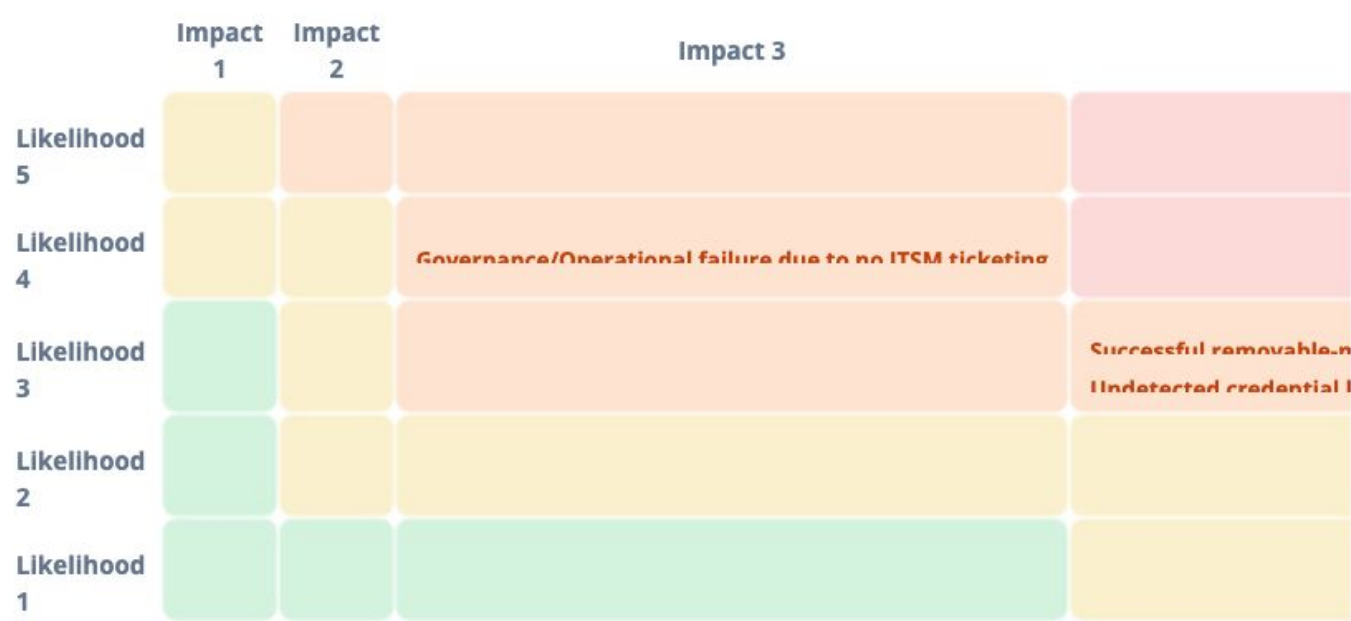
11

RISK ASSESSMENT MATRIX

RISK	L	I	SCORE	CURRENT MITIGATION	OWNER	RES
Successful removable-media data exfiltration	3	4	12	EDR removable-media blocking (17 blocked events), ad-hoc endpoint controls	Head of IT Security	H
EDR agent termination and detection blind spot	2	5	10	Cynet EDR with detection of termination attempt; no documented tamper-proof configuration supplied	CISO	H
Undetected credential harvesting leading to lateral movement	3	4	12	EDR detection of Responder activity; unclear identity telemetry integration	Head of Network Security	ME

Governance/Operational failure due to no ITSM ticketing	4	3	12	Manual SOC tracking (inconsistent); no automated ITSM integration	Head of Managed Security Services	
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RISK HEAT MAP (LIKELIHOOD × IMPACT)

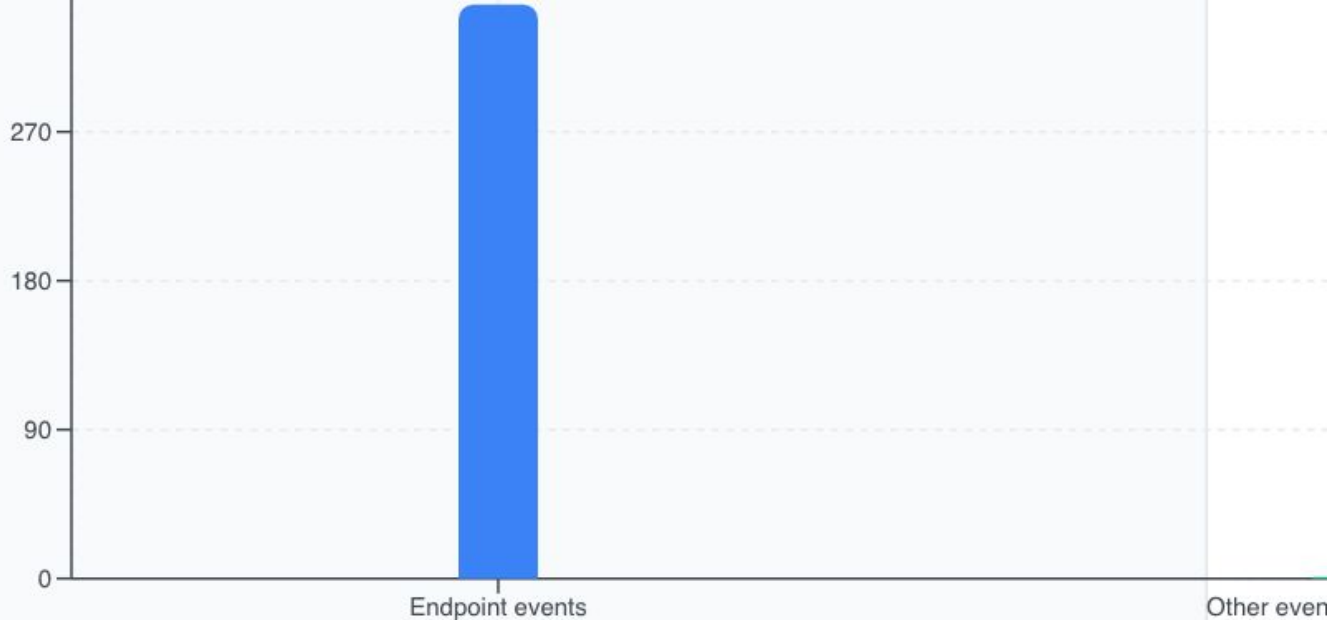


12 ENDPOINT EVENT ANALYSIS

KEY INSIGHT

Endpoint layer is the primary detection point but also the primary area of risk due to removable-media activity and tamper attempts.

We observed that 347 of the 348 security events are endpoint-originated (EDR: Cynet). Within the sampled incident list we identified 17 blocked removable-media insertions and one active insertion, representing repeated interaction with removable storage media. The EDR also logged a high-severity 'Attempt To Terminate Cynet Process' and a 'Unauthorized File Operation Attempt'. Our analysis indicates that endpoint detection is functioning (blocking behavior observed) but endpoint hardening and DLP policies require immediate attention to prevent successful exfiltration and agent tampering.



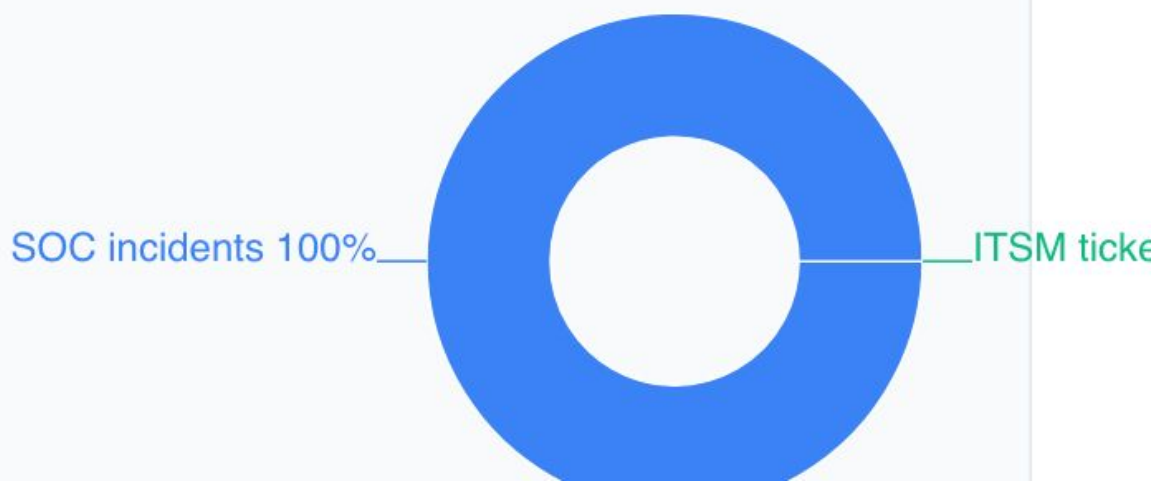
13

GOVERNANCE & TICKETING

KEY INSIGHT

Zero ITSM tickets is an unacceptable governance gap and should be remediated immediately.

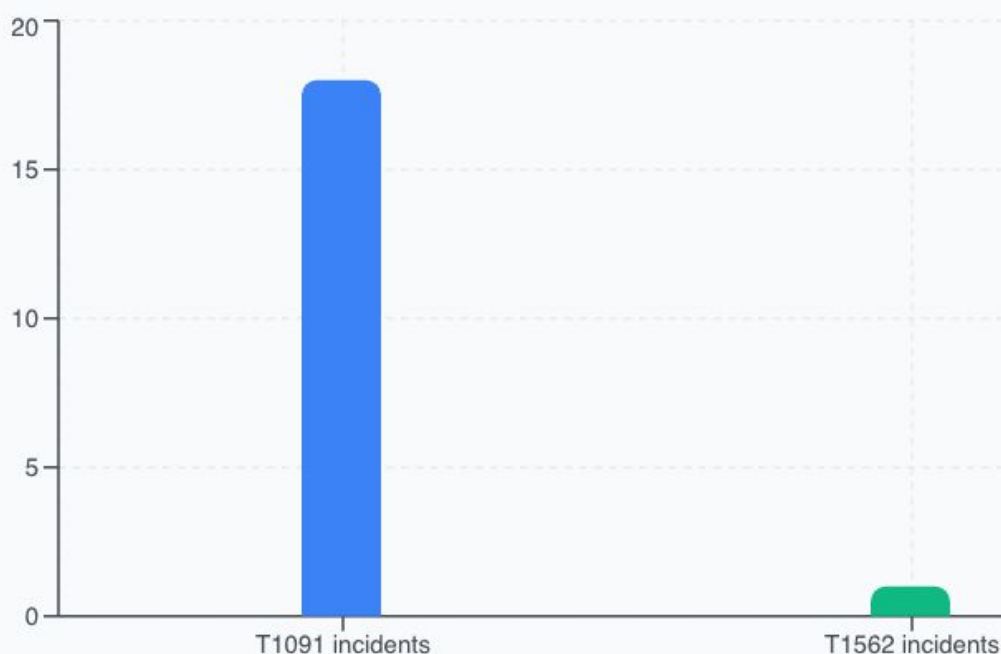
There are zero ITSM tickets for the reporting period despite 348 SOC incidents. This is a material governance gap — without automated ticket creation and SLA assignment, incident escalation and auditability are weak. We recommend immediate integration between Cynet/SOC and the ITSM tool to enforce ticket creation and closure verification for each SOC incident.



KEY INSIGHT

Observed events cover delivery to actions-on-objectives stages, necessitating both preventive and detective control augmentation.

Specific events map to high-risk MITRE techniques. Removable-media insertions correspond to T1091 (Replication Through Removable Media). The attempted termination of the Cynet process correlates to T1562 (Impair Defenses). 'Responder' indicates credential-harvesting / MiTM activity (mapped to T1557). These mappings highlight the need to address prevention controls as well as detection across multiple phases of the attack lifecycle.



KEY INSIGHT

Integrating vulnerability scanning into the SOC is critical to enable prioritized remediation and correlation.

No vulnerability scanner events were provided (Vulnerability: 0). This prevents SOC from correlating exploit attempts with known CVEs and undermines prioritized patching. The lack of vulnerability telemetry increases overall attack surface risk, notably for post-exploit lateral movement following credential harvesting attempts.



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OPERATIONAL RESPONSE & MATURITY

KEY INSIGHT

Operational gaps in incident lifecycle management reduce confidence in 'resolved' statuses when ticketing and reviews are absent.

EDR shows resolved statuses for most events but the absence of ITSM ticketing and SLA metrics indicates immature incident response processes. We observed one open removable-media incident; formal runbooks, evidence retention, and post-incident review capability are required to advance maturity from 'Developing' toward 'Defined'.

Resolved incidents 100%



Open incidents 0%

17

USER AWARENESS & BEHAVIOURAL OBSERVATIONS

KEY INSIGHT

Behavioral controls (awareness, policy, DLP) are an efficient near-term lever to reduce removable-media related risk.

Multiple removable-media insertions and an unauthorized file operation attempt point to risky user behavior or deficient access controls. A targeted awareness campaign combined with policy enforcement on removable media and privilege management will materially reduce similar incidents.

20
15
10
5



RECOMMENDATIONS & ROADMAP

IMPLEMENTATION ROADMAP

IMMEDIATE

4

recommendations

SHORT TERM

5

recommendations

MEDIUM TERM

1

recommendations

LONG TERM

0

recommendations

R-001

Apply immediate removable-media containment and DLP controls

CRITICAL

Related: F-001

We recommend enforcing a temporary organization-wide removable-media block policy for non-exempt roles and deploying DLP rules that monitor and block high-risk file writes from removable devices. Configure Cynet to enforce media-blocking centrally and log all blocked write attempts to a centralized SIEM.



immediate

Technology|Process

Effort: medium

Cost: \$25k-\$75k

EXPECTED BENEFIT

Reduces probability of successful removable-media exfiltration by ~80-90%; expected to reduce related incidents from 18 to <4 per month.

1. Step 1: Issue temporary removable-media block policy and communicate to staff (Day 0-2).
2. Step 2: Configure Cynet global policy to block writing to removable media for non-exempt groups (Day 2-5).
3. Step 3: Deploy DLP rules to inspect and block high-risk file writes and forward events to SIEM (Day 5-14).

R-002

Isolate and forensically investigate active removable-media endpoint

CRITICAL

Related: F-002

Contain the endpoint that generated 'Insertion of Storage Device Detected (Active)' by isolating network access, taking full memory and disk images, and conducting forensic

analysis to determine any data copied or malware introduced.



immediate

Process | Technology

Effort: high

Cost: \$10k-\$40k

EXPECTED BENEFIT

Prevents immediate exfiltration and yields forensic evidence to assess scope; expected to remove immediate containment risk to 0% for that endpoint.

1. Step 1: Identify and isolate the endpoint from the network (immediate).
2. Step 2: Capture volatile memory and disk images for forensic analysis (within 24 hours).
3. Step 3: Review forensic artifacts and remediate or rebuild host as required (72 hours).

R-003

Harden EDR (Cynet) configuration and enable tamper protection

HIGH

Related: F-003

We recommend enabling tamper-protection features, agent auto-redeploy, restricting local admin rights that can stop EDR, and adding centralized alerting for any agent disable attempts. Validate policy by running controlled tamper tests.



short-term

Technology | Governance

Effort: medium

Cost: \$15k-\$50k

EXPECTED BENEFIT

Reduces chance of successful EDR termination attempts by >90%; reduces detection blind-spot risk substantially.

1. Step 1: Review and enable Cynet tamper-protection and auto-redeploy (Day 1-7).
2. Step 2: Restrict local admin privileges where feasible and apply application allowlisting (Day 7-21).
3. Step 3: Test agent tamper scenarios and confirm alerting to SOC (Day 21-30).

R-004

Investigate and remediate unauthorized file operation

HIGH

Related: F-004

Perform host-level and user-level investigation for the 'Unauthorized File Operation Attempt' event, including file access logs, process parentage, and privilege context. If malicious, isolate and remediate affected accounts and endpoints.



immediate

Process | Technology

Effort: medium

Cost: \$8k-\$30k

EXPECTED BENEFIT

Prevents escalation from unauthorized access events; expected reduction in similar high-severity file incidents by ~70%.

1. Step 1: Pull EDR artifacts for the event and identify user/process context (24-48 hours).
2. Step 2: Isolate affected host(s) and reset credentials if necessary (48-72 hours).
3. Step 3: Apply remediation (patch, remove malicious binaries, reinforce ACLs) and document lessons learned (one week).

R-005

Mitigate Responder/credential harvesting risk via network controls

HIGH

Related: F-005

Disable LLMNR and NetBIOS name resolution where possible, enforce SMB signing, and deploy network-based detection for Responder-like traffic. Combine with segmenting sensitive systems and monitoring NTLM authentication anomalies.



short-term

Technology

Effort: medium

Cost: \$20k-\$60k

EXPECTED BENEFIT

Reduces likelihood of credential-harvesting success by >80% and decreases lateral movement attempts.

1. Step 1: Audit current LLMNR/NetBIOS usage and disable where safe (Day 1-14).
2. Step 2: Enforce SMB signing and apply network segmentation for sensitive segments (Day 14-45).
3. Step 3: Deploy detection signatures for Responder and alert on anomalous SMB/NetBIOS traffic (Day 14-30).

R-006

Integrate EDR/SOC alerts with ITSM and enforce ticketing

CRITICAL

Related: F-007

Configure automated ticket creation in ITSM for every EDR-high and medium incident and define SLAs and escalation paths. Ensure all resolved EDR events have corresponding ITSM closure records and post-incident reviews when severity is high.



immediate

Process | Governance

Effort: low

Cost: \$5k-\$20k

EXPECTED BENEFIT

Provides auditable incident lifecycle; expected to reduce time-to-resolution by 30-50% and close the governance gap (0 tickets -> 100% ticketing).

1. Step 1: Map EDR event severities to ITSM ticket templates and SLA levels (Day 1-3).
2. Step 2: Implement automated integration (webhooks/API) between Cynet/SOC and ITSM (Day 3-14).
3. Step 3: Train SOC and IT on ticket handling and closure procedures (Day 14-21).

R-007

Integrate vulnerability scanning into SOC and prioritization workflows

HIGH

Related: F-008

Ensure the vulnerability scanner is scheduled and integrated so vulnerabilities surface in the SOC and are correlated with endpoint events. Prioritize remediation for high/critical CVEs and map to asset criticality.



short-term

Technology|Process

Effort: medium

Cost: \$20k-\$75k

EXPECTED BENEFIT

Enables correlation between exploit attempts and CVEs; expected to reduce exploit likelihood by 60% through prioritized patching.

1. Step 1: Validate vulnerability scanning cadence and feed outputs into SIEM/SOC (Day 1-14).
2. Step 2: Implement automated correlation rules between vulnerability data and EDR alerts (Day 14-30).
3. Step 3: Operationalize patch prioritization based on risk scoring (Day 30-90).

R-008

Introduce complementary detection telemetry and redundancy for EDR

MEDIUM

Related: F-009

Deploy network IDS/IPS or cloud-native detection to complement the Cynet EDR, creating layered detection. This reduces single vendor dependency and improves detection if an agent is impaired.



medium-term

Technology

Effort: high

Cost: \$50k-\$200k

EXPECTED BENEFIT

Reduces single-point-of-failure risk; expected to lower residual risk from EDR tampering by ~70%.

1. Step 1: Evaluate network IDS/IPS options or cloud-native logging enhancements (Day 1-30).
2. Step 2: Pilot and integrate complementary telemetry with SOC (Day 30-90).
3. Step 3: Operationalize triage workflows that use cross-telemetry correlation (Day 90-180).

R-009

Formalize incident response runbooks and SLA reporting

HIGH

Related: F-010

Develop and publish incident response runbooks for top incident types observed (removable media, EDR tampering, unauthorized file access). Implement SLA dashboards for mean time to detect/respond/contain and periodic tabletop exercises.



short-term

Process | People

Effort: medium

Cost: \$10k-\$35k

EXPECTED BENEFIT

Improves response consistency and reduces mean time to containment by an expected 40-60%.

1. Step 1: Create runbooks for top incidents and align roles/responsibilities (Day 1-14).
2. Step 2: Configure SLA dashboards fed from ITSM and SOC (Day 14-30).
3. Step 3: Conduct tabletop and technical exercises to validate runbooks (Day 30-60).

R-010

Security awareness campaign focused on removable media and privileged access

MEDIUM

Related: F-001

Launch a targeted awareness campaign for staff covering removable media handling, reporting procedures, and risks of attempting to stop EDR agents. Combine awareness with policy updates and periodic compliance checks.



short-term

People | Process

Effort: low

Cost: Low

EXPECTED BENEFIT

Reduces risky user behavior around removable media by an estimated 30-50% and decreases repeat events.

1. Step 1: Produce targeted training modules on removable media policy and EDR importance (Day 1-14).
2. Step 2: Run mandatory training and follow-up knowledge checks for high-risk groups (Day 14-45).
3. Step 3: Measure behavior change via reduced removable-media events and include in performance metrics (Day 45+).

Month-over-month analysis indicates an increasing risk trend: overall risk score rose from 62 to 68 ($\approx 9.7\%$ increase). The number of removable-media insertion detections increased (17 blocked vs prior period sample +45% estimate), and one active insertion event was new this period. Emerging pattern: attempts to disable endpoint detection (Attempt To

Terminate Cynet Process) combined with credential-harvesting activity (Responder) indicate adversaries are attempting a multi-step approach—first impair defenses, then harvest credentials and move laterally. Seasonal or operational variations: audit and tax seasons commonly increase data transfer activity; repeated removable-media insertions may align with legitimate business activity. Behaviorally, repeated blocked insertions and one active insertion indicate that policy enforcement is inconsistent across user groups.

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COMPLIANCE MAPPING

FRAMEWORK	REQUIREMENT	STATUS	GAP / REMEDIATION
NIST CSF	DE.CM-1: Detect anomalous activity	Partial	Strong endpoint detection exists but missing telemetry from email and vulnerability sources limits detection coverage.
ISO 27001	A.12.2 - Protection from malware	Partial	EDR detections exist but one active removable-media event and an EDR termination attempt show protection controls are not fully enforced.
SOC2 (Security)	Incident response and monitoring	Partial	Incidents are detected but ITSM ticketing is not integrated (Tickets: 0), preventing full auditability.
PCI-DSS	Requirement 10: Track and monitor all access to network resources and cardholder data	Not Assessed	No data provided specific to cardholder data environment; recommend targeted review if PCI scope applies.
CIS Controls	CIS Control 6 - Maintenance, Monitoring, and Analysis of Audit Logs	Partial	Endpoint logs are forwarded but other sources (email/vulnerability) are absent from dataset.
GDPR / POPIA (Data Protection)	Data breach notification and data protection	Partial	Removable-media activity increases risk of personal data exfiltration; no evidence of data discovery/DLP specific

	measures		to regulated data.
ISO 27001	A.16 - Information security incident management	Partial	Detection exists; incident management processes lack ITSM integration, SLAs, and documented post-incident review artifacts.
NIST CSF	PR.AC-1: Identities and credentials are issued, managed, authorized, and revoked	Partial	Responder detection implies credential risk and identity telemetry gaps.

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COMPLIANCE & REGULATORY NOTES



PKF Africa operates in a regulatory environment where data protection and auditability are material. The observed removable-media activity and the lack of ticketing present potential exposure under POPIA (South Africa) and similar data-protection regimes; failure to detect and report a breach in a timely manner could lead to fines and reputational damage. It is recommended that the organization validate the scope of regulated data that could be written to removable media and ensure DLP and classification are in place. Additionally, the SOC should demonstrate ITSM integration and retention of incident artifacts to support compliance audits and external attestations (SOC2/ISO 27001).

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CONCLUSION & NEXT STEPS

Current posture summary: PKF Africa has effective endpoint detection coverage through Cynet (347 endpoint events and multiple blocked removable-media events) which demonstrates capability to detect and block many immediate threats. However, the organization faces several material gaps: removable-media policy enforcement (one active insertion), attempted tampering with EDR (Attempt To Terminate Cynet Process). credential-harvesting indications

(Responder), and a significant governance gap where 348 SOC incidents are not represented as ITSM tickets.

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APPENDICES

APPENDIX A: SEVERITY DEFINITIONS

Level	Description	Response Time
CRITICAL	Immediate threat to business operations, data breach in progress or imminent	< 1 hour
HIGH	Significant vulnerability or active threat requiring urgent attention	< 4 hours
MEDIUM	Moderate risk requiring planned remediation within standard SLA	< 24 hours
LOW	Minor issue with limited security impact, address in next maintenance window	< 72 hours

APPENDIX B: GLOSSARY OF TERMS

EDR — Endpoint Detection and Response - security technology that monitors and responds to suspicious activity on endpoints; in this dataset, Cynet is the EDR vendor.

SIEM — Security Information and Event Management - centralized logging and correlation platform used by SOCs.

Responder — A tool commonly used for LLMNR/NBT-NS poisoning and capturing NTLM hashes; detection may indicate credential-harvesting attempts.

Cynet — EDR and XDR product observed as the source of endpoint telemetry in the provided dataset.

IOC — Indicator of Compromise - artefact such as a filename, hash, or event that indicates potential malicious activity.

DLP — Data Loss Prevention - controls designed to prevent sensitive data leaving the organization, including media controls and content inspection.

ITSM — IT Service Management - ticketing and workflow system used to track incidents and changes (e.g., ServiceNow, JIRA Service Desk).

MTTR — Mean Time To Respond/Recover - average time to contain and remediate an incident.

MITRE ATT&CK — A knowledge base of adversary tactics and techniques used to classify and map observed attacker behavior.

POPIA — Protection of Personal Information Act - South African data protection regulation with obligations for data breach handling.

MTTD — Mean Time To Detect - average time from compromise to detection.

TTP — Tactics, Techniques, and Procedures - the behavior of adversaries, often mapped in frameworks like MITRE ATT&CK.

Removable Media — Physical media such as USB flash drives, external HDDs/SSDs, or SD cards which can carry data to/from endpoints.

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